

Interview Prompt Cards

For the mock-interview rounds. The "user" picks a real problem area they genuinely have and answers truthfully. Interviewers do **not** pitch — they learn.

How to use (triads — 3 rounds)

Interviewer

Good, non-leading questions to understand the problem — no solutions, no pitching.

User

Pick a card (page 2) you *actually* experience; answer from your own life.

Observer

Tally leading questions and capture the real needs that surface (page 2).

Rotate roles each round so everyone is Interviewer once.

Interviewer's funnel — works for any topic; you're starting cold

- 1. Open the area (~30 sec):** "Tell me about [their topic] — how does that usually go for you?"
- 2. Get a real, recent instance:** "When did it last go wrong or frustrate you? Walk me through it."
- 3. Follow what they actually do:** "What do you do about it now?" — their **workaround** is where the hidden need lives.
- 4. Ladder to the root — ask "why" 2–3 times:** "Why was that the hard part?" → "And why does *that* matter?"
- 5. Measure the pain:** "How often does this happen? What does it cost you — time, money, stress?"
- 6. Reflect it back:** "So it sounds like the real headache is ____ — is that right?"
- 7. If time:** "If you could wave a wand and fix one part of this, which would it be?"

Reaching the issue they haven't named

People hand you a **symptom** ("group projects are stressful"), not the root problem. You reach the real, often-unspoken need by **following the workaround** (a pain they've quietly accepted), asking "**why / what happens then**" a couple of times to climb from symptom to stake, and **reflecting it back** until they say "*yeah — exactly.*"

Worked example — topic the "user" picked: group projects

- I:** "Tell me about group projects — how do they usually go?"
- U:** "Honestly, stressful."
- I:** "When did one last stress you out? Walk me through it."
- U:** "Last week I ended up doing most of the slides the night before."
- I:** "How did it get to that point?"
- U:** "People said they'd do their parts and didn't — I found out too late."
- I:** "What do you do about that now?" (*workaround*)
- U:** "I just assume I'll have to redo things, so I over-prepare."
- I:** "Why is finding out *late* the hard part?" (*why-ladder*)
- U:** "Because by then there's no time to fix it without doing it myself."
- I:** "So the real headache is you can't tell whether the work is actually happening until it's too late to react — is that it?" (*reflect back*)
- U:** "Yeah, exactly. It's not the work — it's the not-knowing."

Surface complaint: "stressful group projects." The real, previously-unnamed need: **visibility into whether teammates are on track, early enough to act** — reached in five questions, on a topic the interviewer knew nothing about going in.

Problem-Area Cards & Observer Tally

User: pick one you truly relate to. Cut along the dashed lines if you want loose cards.

1 Commuting / parking / getting to class The daily logistics that go wrong.	2 Group projects Coordinating, dividing work, dealing with free-riders.
3 Managing money as a student Budgeting, splitting costs, tracking spending.	4 Finding and protecting time Study, work, church, social, sleep.
5 A hobby or side interest The genuinely annoying part of doing it.	6 A job or campus role A task that's more painful than it should be.
7 Health / fitness routines Starting, tracking, and sticking with them.	8 Keeping up with a club / ward / community Communication, events, coordination.
9 Cooking / meals / groceries The recurring hassle.	10 A tool or app you use that frustrates you Where it falls short.

Observer's tally sheet

	ROUND 1	ROUND 2	ROUND 3
Topic card #			
Leading questions caught			
Real needs / pain points heard			
Best "walk me through the last time" moment			